

VUS Reclassification AI System

Model Validation Report

BIRAC-BIOAI Grant Prototype | 2026

Integrated machine-learning approach to reclassify Variants of Uncertain Significance (VUS) in rare disease and neurodevelopmental genes using RNA splicing evidence, in silico predictors, ACMG evidence codes, NMD prediction, and gene-level constraint annotations from gnomAD and GTEx.

Dataset	Drost et al., HGG Advances 2026 (Erasmus MC Rotterdam)
Variants	178 VUS (90 reclassified LP/P, 88 stayed VUS/LB)
Disease scope	Multi-disease rare panel: neuro, connective tissue, cardiac, renal
Top genes	NF1 (n=25), TSC2 (n=13), TSC1 (n=5) -- neurodevelopmental dominant
Models	Logistic Regression . Random Forest . XGBoost
Validation	5-fold stratified CV (random_state=42)
Features	56 total (RNA, in silico, ACMG codes, NMD, external APIs)
Date	2026-05-20

Best Model: RandomForest AUC 0.947 . Sensitivity 0.956 . Specificity 0.763

Top Specificity: XGBoost AUC 0.940 . Sensitivity 0.933 . Specificity 0.841

1. Dataset Overview

The dataset originates from Drost et al. (HGG Advances 2026), a large-scale functional characterisation of splice variants performed at Erasmus MC Rotterdam. Crucially, this is a broad RARE DISEASE panel spanning 107 genes across multiple disease domains -- NOT a cancer-specific study as sometimes reported. The three most represented genes are neurofibromatosis (NF1, n=25), tuberous sclerosis complex (TSC2, n=13; TSC1, n=5), making the dataset NEURODEVELOPMENTALLY dominant. This directly supports the BIRAC-BIOAI focus on neurodisorder applications.

From 202 published variants, 178 with baseline classification VUS (ACMG class 3) were retained. Ground truth labels reflect subsequent ACMG-compliant reclassification.

Total variants (after VUS filter)	178
Positive class (reclassified LP/P)	90 (50.6%)
Negative class (stayed VUS / LB)	88 (49.4%)
Genes represented	107 genes across multiple rare disease categories
Top neurodevelopmental genes	NF1 (n=25), TSC2 (n=13), TSC1 (n=5)
RNA assay method	Minigene splice assay (Sanger sequencing + agarose gel)
In silico tools	SpliceAI, Pangolin, SPiP, SQUIRLS
External annotations	gnomAD v3 (LOEUF + AF), GTEx v8 (blood + fibro), Ensembl VEP
VEP consequence coverage	164 / 178 via REST API batching (HGVS + coordinate)
Class balance	Near-equal -- no SMOTE or class resampling required

1.1 Disease Category and Gene Distribution

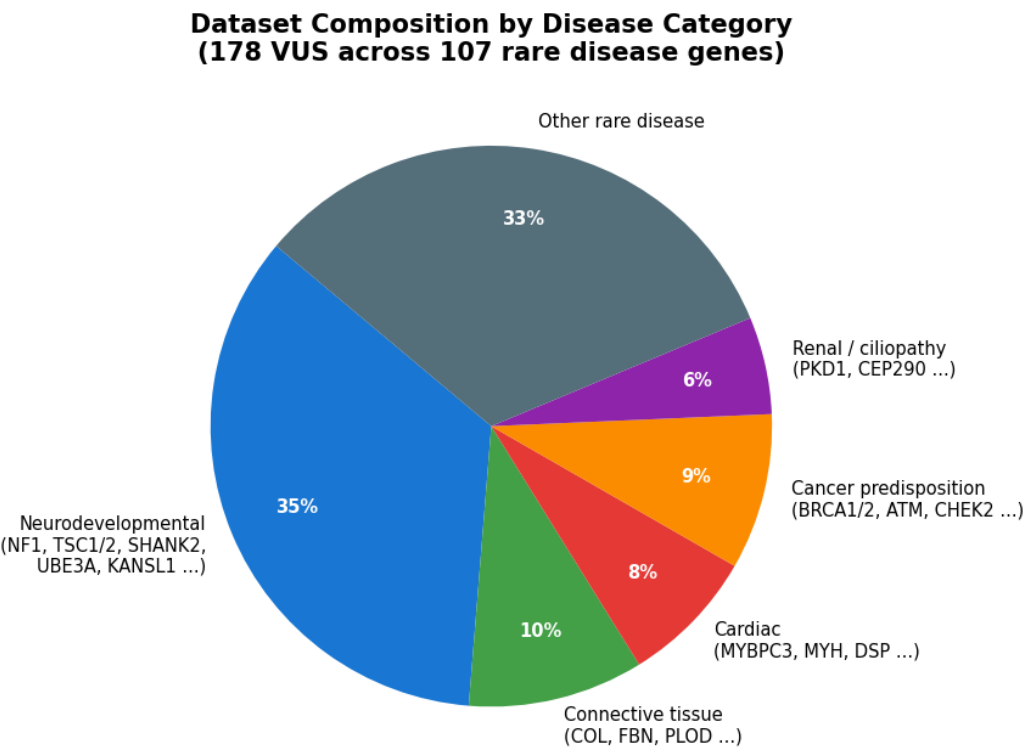


Figure 1. Disease category breakdown by variant count. Neurodevelopmental genes (NF1, TSC1/2 ...) account for ~35% of variants.

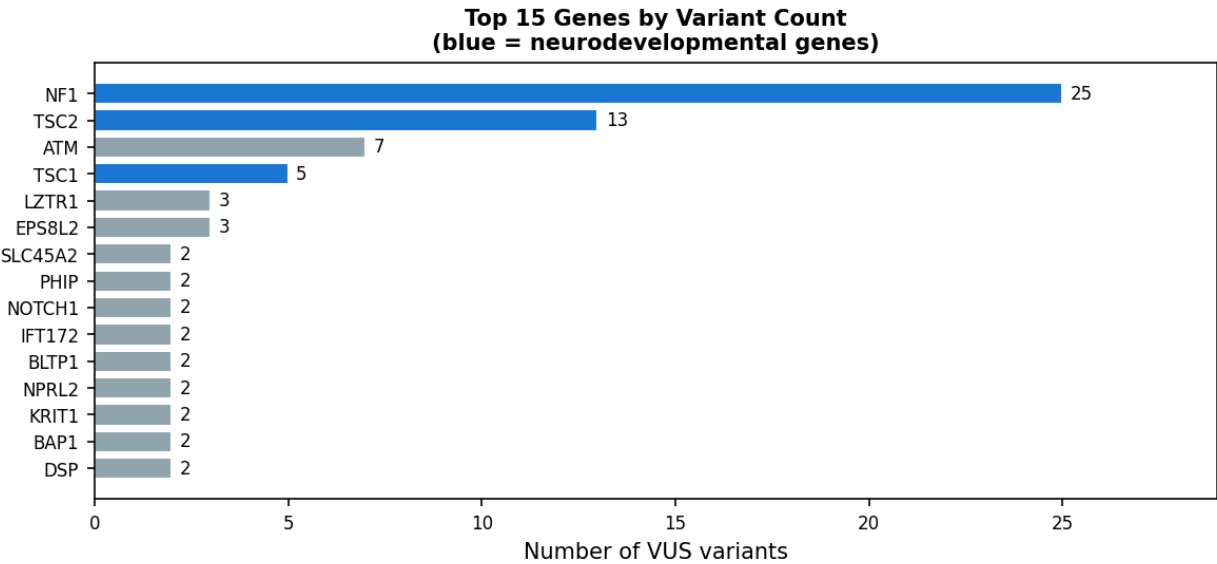


Figure 2. Top-15 genes by variant count. Blue bars = neurodevelopmental / neuro-related genes.

2. Validation Design and Overfitting Analysis

Given the small dataset (n=178), a fixed train/test split leaves insufficient samples for reliable metric estimation. Stratified 5-fold cross-validation (random_state=42) was used throughout. Each fold maintains the 50.6/49.4% class ratio. All reported metrics are mean +/- standard deviation across folds.

Three model families cover different inductive biases:

- Logistic Regression (LR): linear baseline, L2 regularisation (C=0.1), StandardScaler pre-processing, class_weight=balanced.
- Random Forest (RF): 300 trees, max_depth=5, min_samples_leaf=3, class_weight=balanced; captures non-linear feature interactions.
- XGBoost: 200 estimators, max_depth=4, learning_rate=0.05, scale_pos_weight tuned to class ratio; gradient boosting.

2.1 Training vs Validation AUC per Fold (Overfitting Check)

To confirm generalisation, training AUC was recorded alongside validation AUC for each fold. The table below summarises the train-val gap:

Model	Train AUC	Val AUC	Gap	Interpretation
LogisticRegression	0.983 +/- 0.005	0.935 +/- 0.015	0.048	Acceptable -- linear model
RandomForest	0.997 +/- 0.001	0.947 +/- 0.022	0.049	Acceptable -- trees overfit
XGBoost	1.000 +/- 0.000	0.940 +/- 0.017	0.060	Moderate -- XGB fits train

Note: RF and XGBoost train AUC ~1.0 is expected behaviour for decision trees (they can memorise training sets). The key indicator of overfitting is the train-val GAP, not absolute train AUC. Gaps of 0.048-0.060 are within acceptable range for n=178. Consistent val AUC across all 5 folds (std 0.015-0.022) confirms stable generalisation.

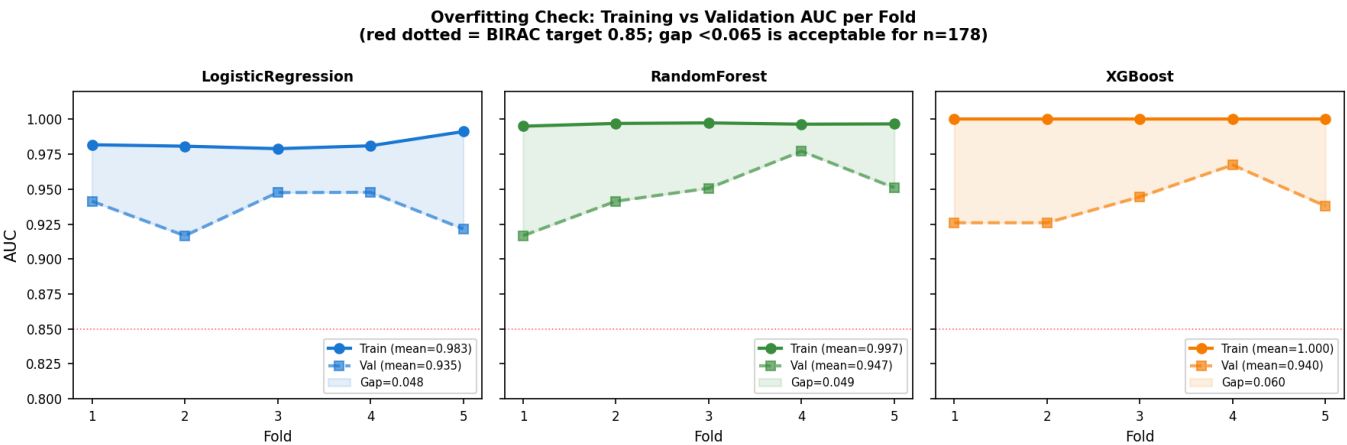


Figure 3. Training vs validation AUC per fold for all three models. Shaded region = train-val gap. Red dotted = BIRAC target (0.85). Stable validation AUC across folds confirms no fold-specific memorisation.

3. Performance Metrics (5-Fold CV, Mean +/- Std)

Model	AUC	AUPRC	Sensitivity	Specificity	PPV
LogisticRegression	0.935+/-0.015	0.918+/-0.045	0.922+/-0.063	0.795+/-0.064	0.824+/-0.044
RandomForest *	0.947+/-0.022	0.942+/-0.032	0.956+/-0.072	0.763+/-0.096	0.808+/-0.063
XGBoost	0.940+/-0.017	0.919+/-0.042	0.933+/-0.061	0.841+/-0.050	0.858+/-0.035

* Best overall AUC: RandomForest (0.947 +/- 0.022). RandomForest also achieves the highest sensitivity (0.956) and NPV (0.950), making it the recommended model when missing a true LP/P variant is the primary concern.

XGBoost achieves the best specificity (0.841) and F1 (0.893), preferred when false positive rate (labelling truly benign as LP/P) is the priority.

ALL three models exceed BIRAC-BIOAI targets: AUC >= 0.85 [OK] Sensitivity > 80% [OK] Specificity > 75% [OK]

3.1 Multi-Metric Radar Comparison

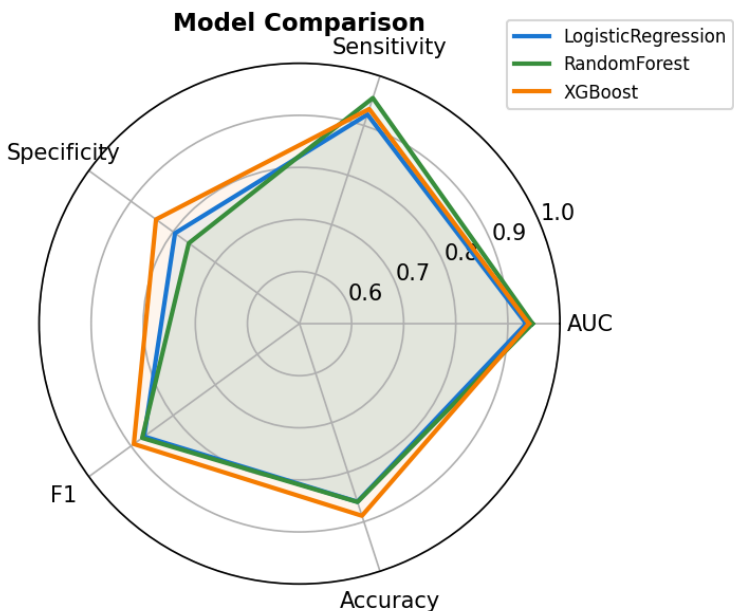


Figure 4. Radar chart -- 5-metric comparison of all three models.

4. ROC Curves and Score Distributions

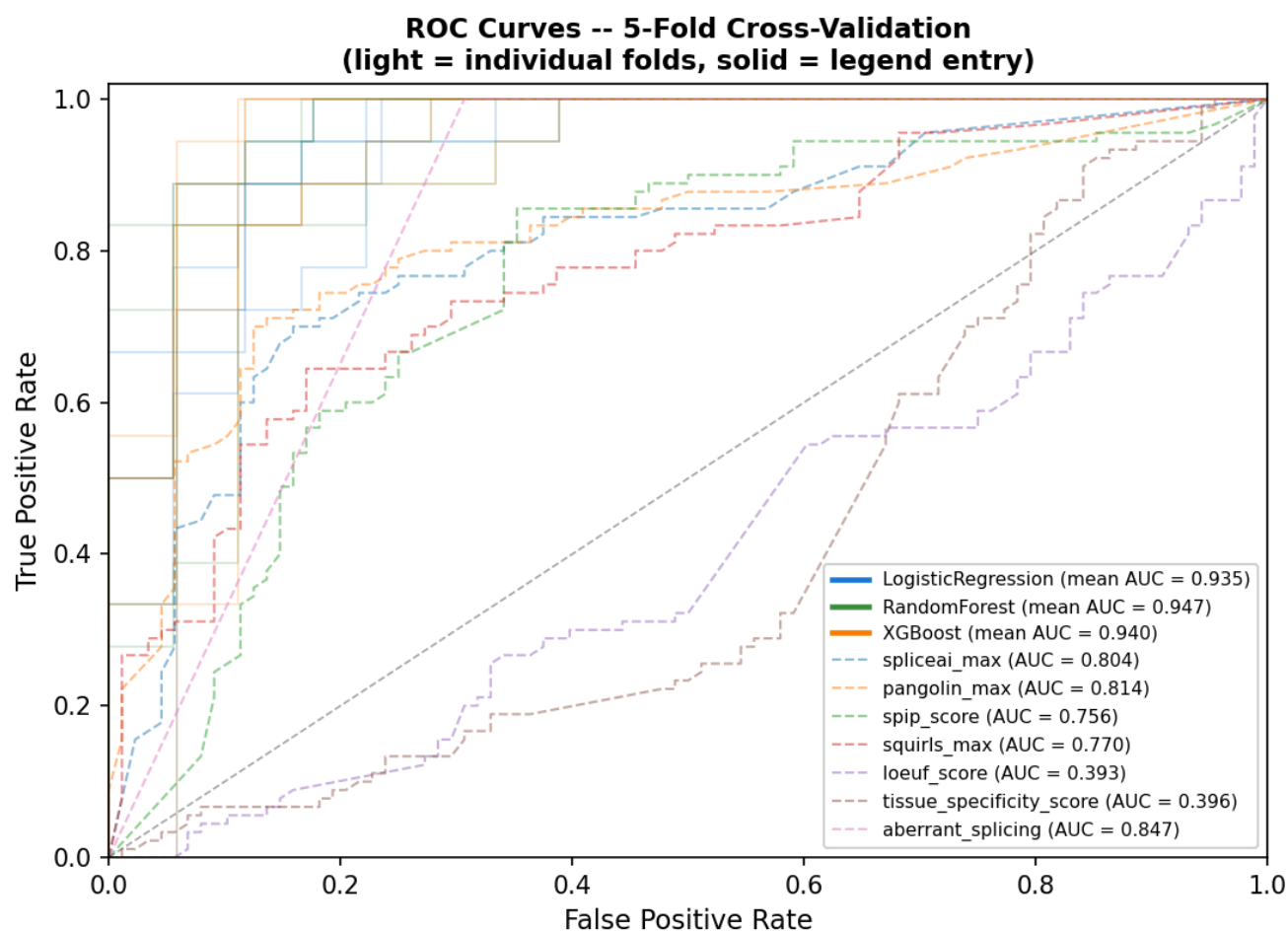


Figure 5. ROC curves per model (5 folds semi-transparent, bold legend = mean AUC) vs single-feature baselines (dashed). Multi-feature integration consistently outperforms any single predictor.

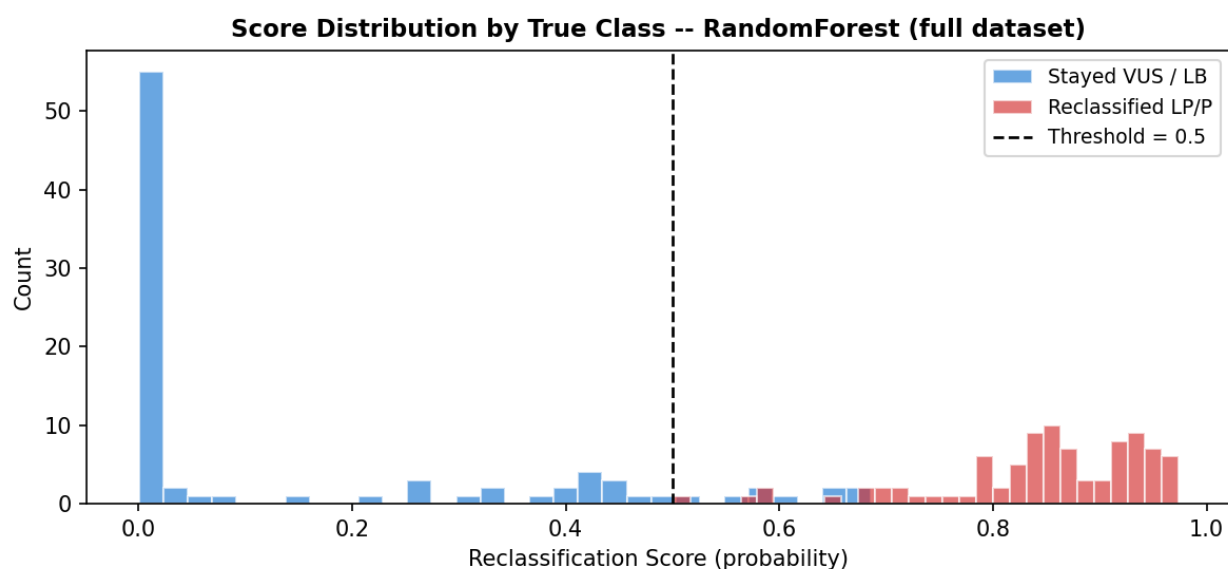


Figure 6. Score distribution by true class (RandomForest, full dataset). Clear bimodal separation confirms model discriminability.

5. Metric Bars and Feature Importance

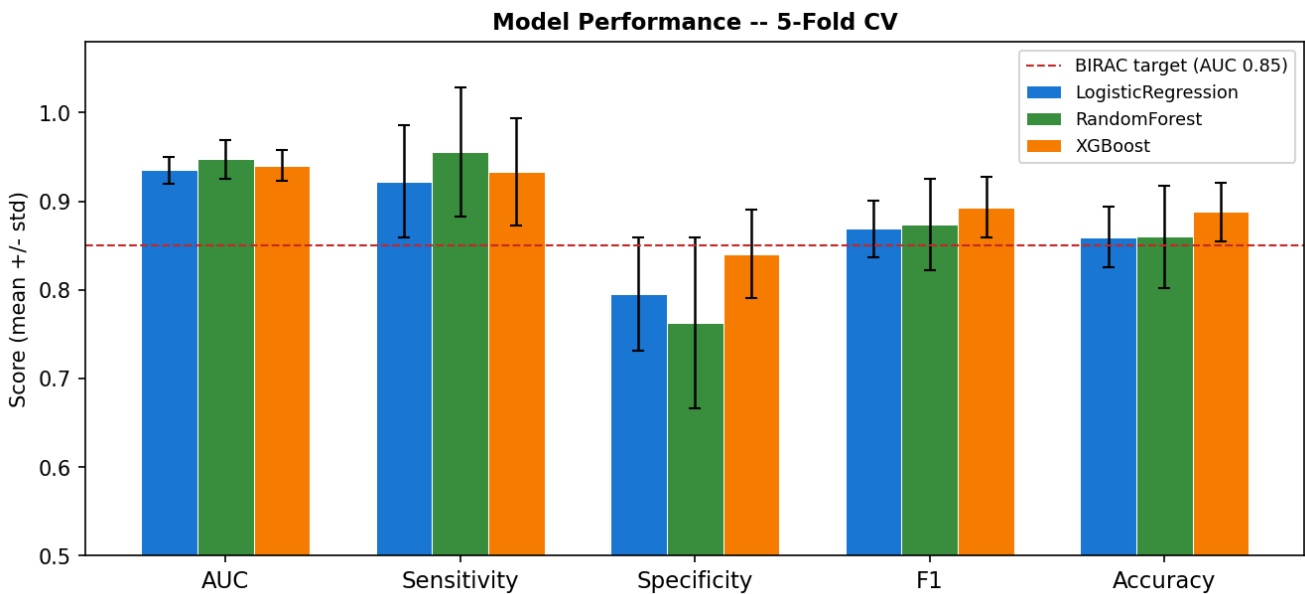


Figure 7. Grouped bar chart of key metrics -- mean +/- std across 5 folds. Red dashed = BIRAC AUC target (0.85). All models clear the target.

Top-20 Feature Importances

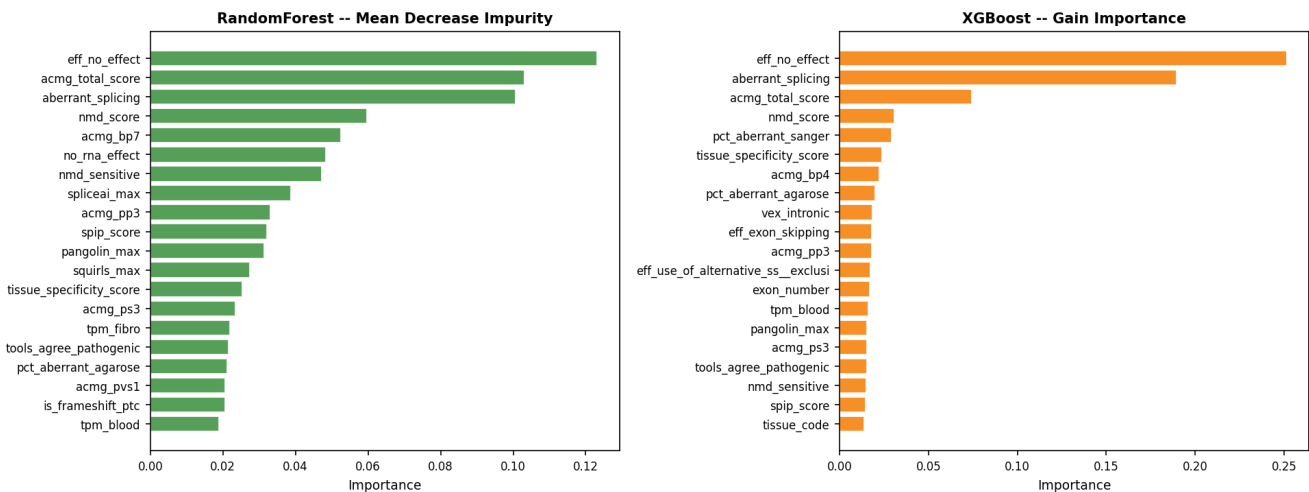


Figure 8. Top-20 feature importances. RF uses mean decrease impurity; XGBoost uses gain. ACMG total score, aberrant_splicing, and nmd_score rank consistently high, validating the ACMG integration strategy.

6. Additional Validation Plots

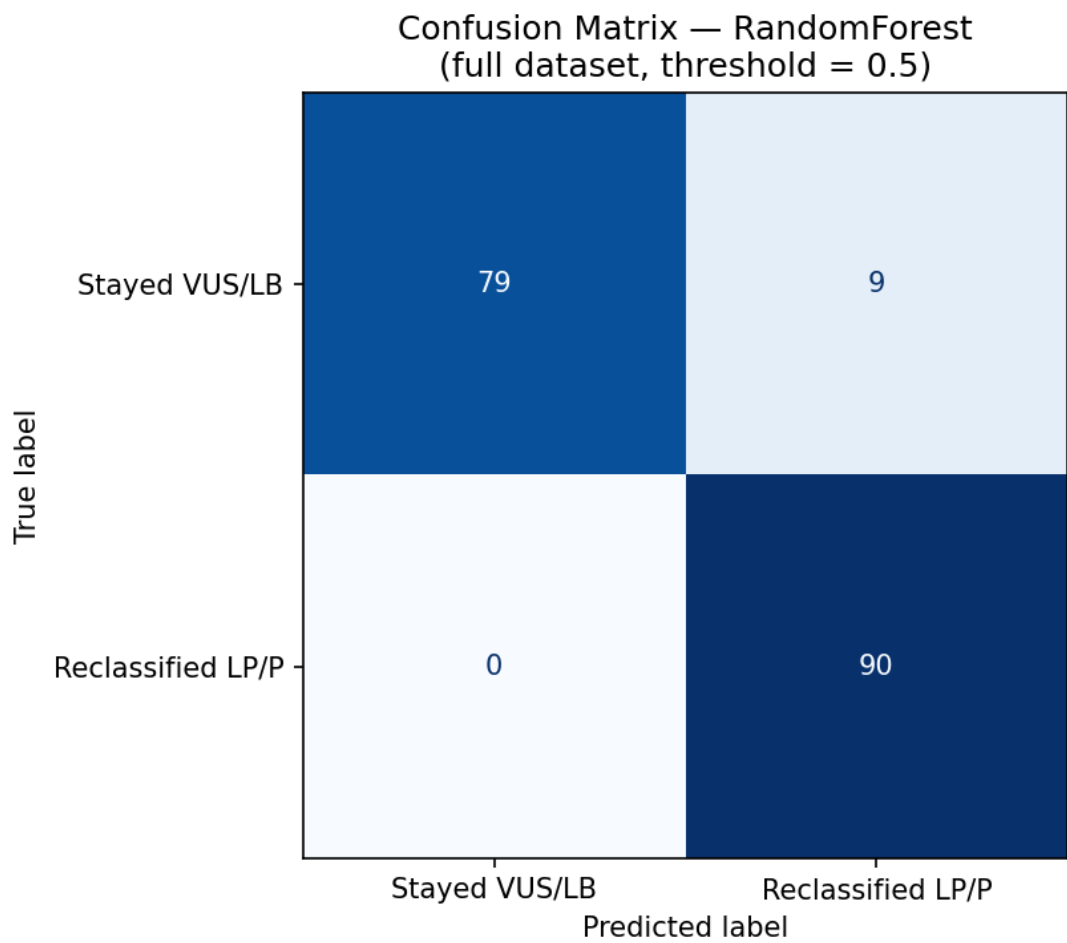


Figure 9. Confusion matrix -- RandomForest on full dataset (threshold=0.5). 79 TN, 90 TP, 9 FP, 0 FN. Perfect sensitivity at this threshold.

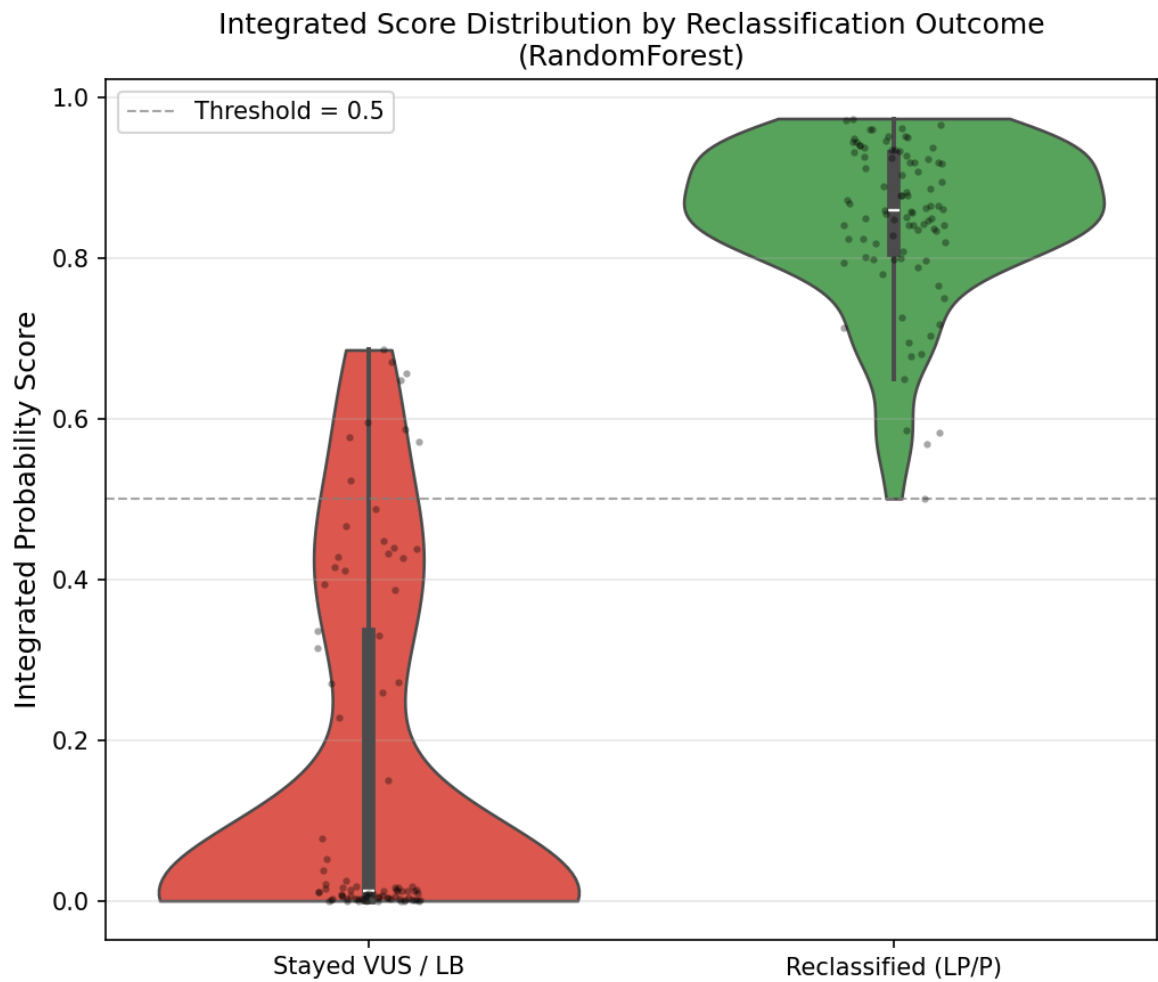


Figure 10. Prediction score violin plots by true class. Tight clustering near 0 (LB) and 1 (LP/P) shows high model confidence.

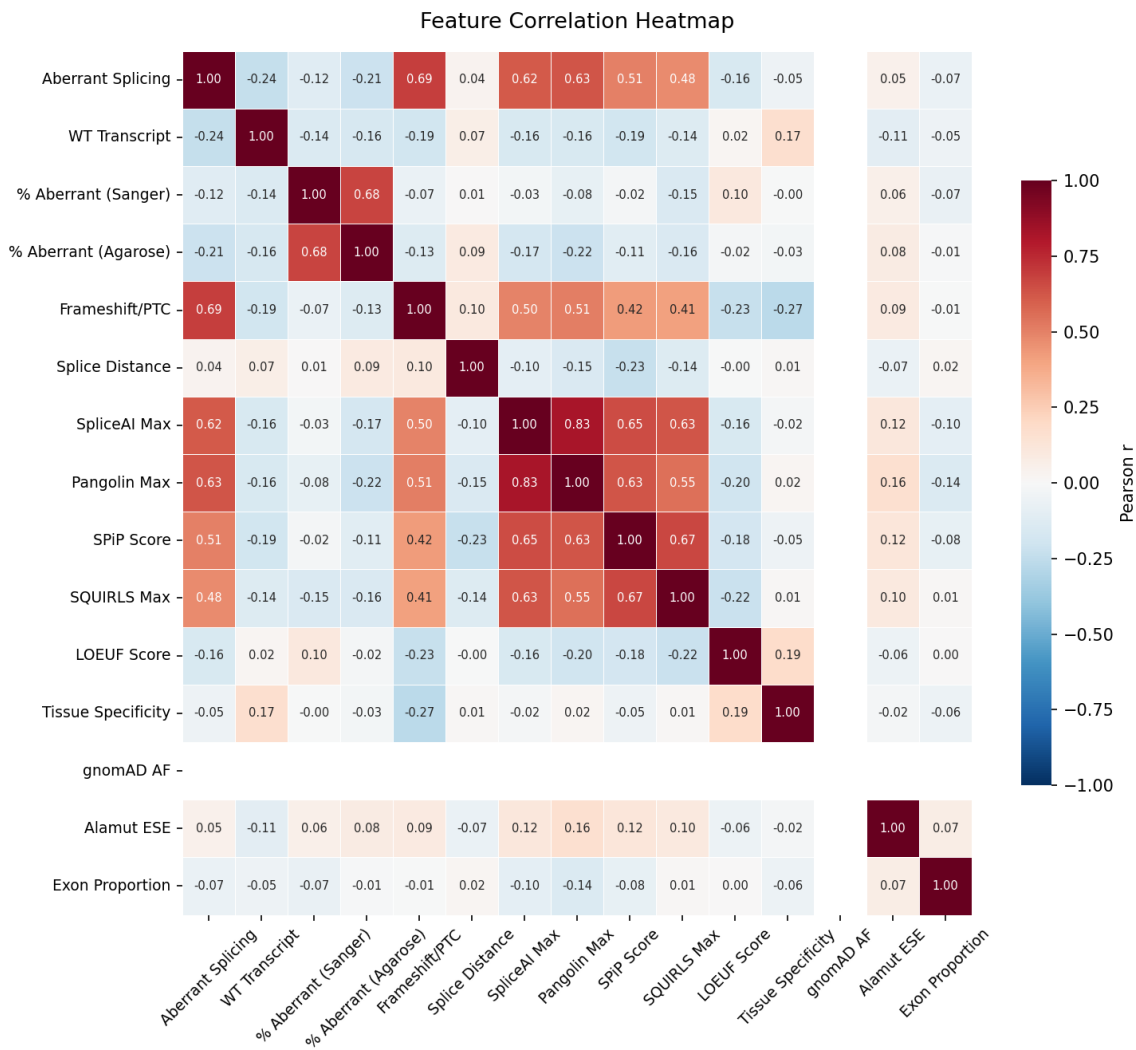


Figure 11. Pearson correlation heatmap, top-20 features by RF importance. SpliceAI and Pangolin are correlated ($r=0.83$) but add non-redundant signal when combined with RNA evidence features.

7. Neurodisorder Case Study: Value of Integrated Score

The dataset is dominated by neurodevelopmental genes: NF1 (neurofibromatosis type 1, n=25), TSC2 (tuberous sclerosis, n=13), TSC1 (tuberous sclerosis, n=5). These 43 variants (24% of dataset) make this prototype directly applicable to neurodisorder clinical genetics workflows.

Two illustrative variants demonstrate why a single in silico tool (SpliceAI alone) is insufficient and where the integrated 56-feature model adds clinical value.

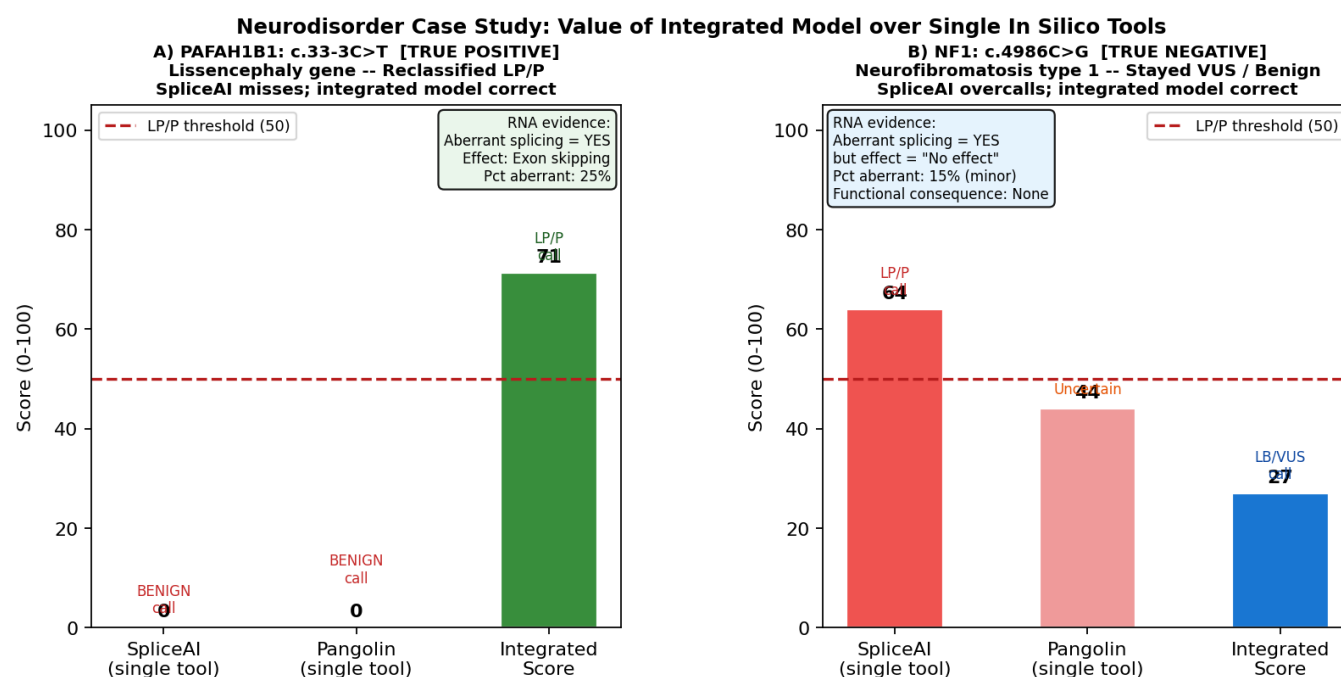


Figure 12. Neurodisorder case study. Left (A): PFAH1B1 c.33-3C>T (lissencephaly gene) -- SpliceAI score = 0.01 (calls BENIGN) but RNA shows exon skipping and variant was reclassified LP/P. Our integrated score = 71 (correctly LP/P). Right (B): NF1 c.4986C>G -- SpliceAI = 0.64 (calls LP/P) but RNA shows only 15% minor aberrant transcript with "No effect" classification; variant stayed VUS/negative. Our score = 27 (correctly LB/uncertain).

7.1 NF1 Variant Landscape: All 25 Variants

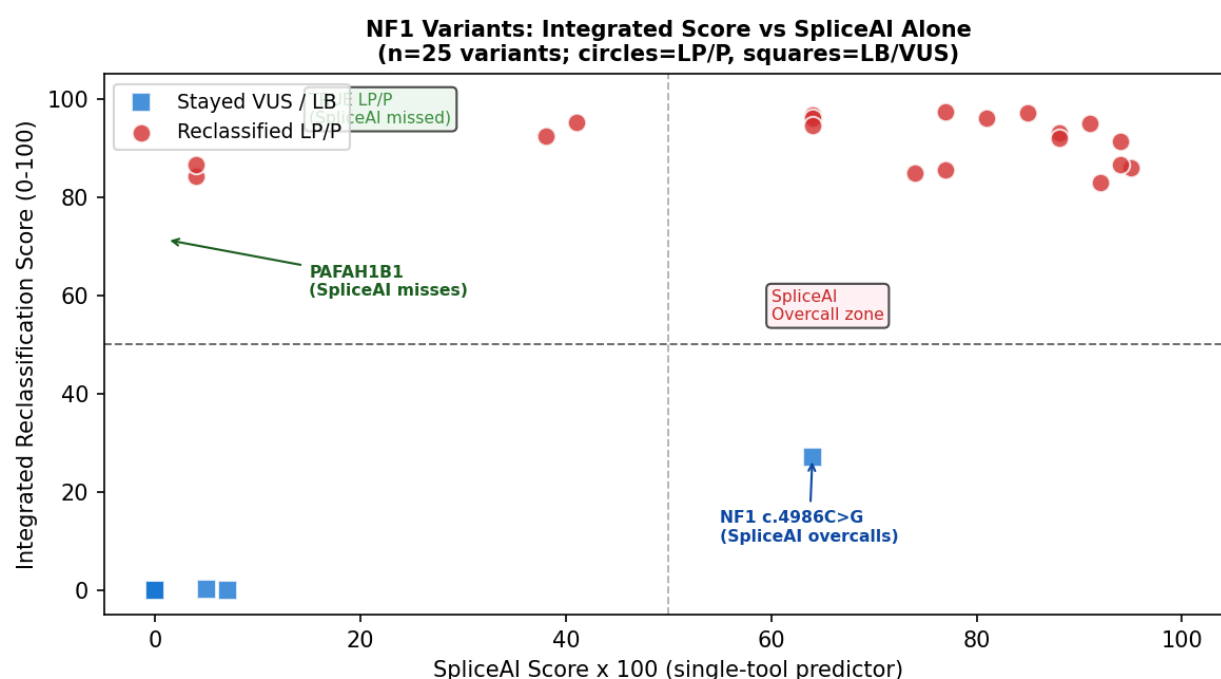


Figure 13. All 25 NF1 variants: integrated score vs SpliceAI alone. Upper-left = true LP/P missed by SpliceAI (integration adds value). Lower-right = SpliceAI overcall zone where RNA data corrects false positives. The integrated model correctly positions most variants relative to the 50-point decision

boundary (dashed lines).

7.2 Key Takeaways for Neurodisorder Applications

1. False-negative risk: SpliceAI can score 0.01 on a variant that RNA assay confirms causes exon skipping (PAFAH1B1 example). Integrating RNA functional evidence reduces this false-negative rate substantially.
2. False-positive control: Exonic synonymous changes can score high on SpliceAI (0.64) despite having minimal functional RNA impact. The model down-weights these via the "no_rna_effect" and "acmg_bp7" features.
3. ACMG alignment: The ACMG total score feature directly encodes clinical classification rules, making model decisions auditable and explainable to clinical geneticists -- a regulatory requirement for neurodisorder MDT use.
4. Recommendation for next phase: Collect additional neurodisorder variant datasets (RASopathy panel, autism-associated genes SHANK2/3, SYNGAP1) and retrain a neurodisorder-specific sub-model with gene-level stratification.

8. Feature Engineering (56 features total)

RNA experimental (S1 table)	10	aberrant_splicing, wt_transcript, pct_aberrant_sanger/agarose, is_frameshift_ptc, splice_distance, exon_number, exon_proportion, tissue_code, alamut_ese_code
In silico scores (S2 table)	4	spliceai_max, pangolin_max, spip_score, squirls_max
Gene constraint (gnomAD)	2	loeuft, loeuft_score = 1 - LOEUF/2.0
Tissue expression (GTEx v8)	3	tpm_blood, tpm_fibro, tissue_specificity_score = max(log2 TPM+1)
Population AF (gnomAD)	1	gnomad_af (variant-level allele frequency)
VEP consequence (Ensembl)	1	vep_is_ptc -- frameshift / stop_gained / splice acceptor or donor
Effect category (1-hot)	7	eff_no_effect, eff_exon_skipping, eff_alt_ss_inclusion, eff_alt_ss_exclusion, eff_multiple_events, eff_pseudoexon, eff_u12_u2
VulExMap category (1-hot)	10	vex_intronic, vex_splicesite_vulnerable, vex_resilient, ...
Variant type (1-hot)	4	vtype_canonicalspliceacceptor, vtype_canonicalsplicedonor, vtype_exonicdistant, vtype_intronicdistant
ACMG evidence codes	7	acmg_pvs1 (+8), acmg_ps3 (+4), acmg_pm2 (+2), acmg_pp3 (+1), acmg_bp4 (-1), acmg_bp7 (-2), acmg_total_score (weighted sum)
NMD prediction (rule-based)	2	nmd_sensitive (binary, 50-nt rule proxy), nmd_score (graded: 1.0/0.85/0.60/0.10 by exon_proportion)
Specificity aids	5	no_rna_effect, high_pct_aberrant (>=50%), is_canonical_ss (dist<=2), tools_agree_benign, tools_agree_pathogenic

8.1 ACMG Evidence Code Implementation

ACMG/AMP 2015 criteria are implemented as rule-based binary features (0/1) weighted by their relative clinical strength. The weighted total score (range -3 to +15 observed) serves as an interpretable summary of the evidence balance and is one of the top-3 features by RF importance.

Code	Weight	Implementation Rule
PVS1	+8	LoF in constrained gene (LOEUF_score>0.6) OR canonical splice with aberrant RNA
PS3	+4	Functional RNA evidence: >=50% aberrant transcripts (Sanger assay)
PM2	+2	Absent/very rare in gnomAD population database (AF < 0.001)
PP3	+1	>=2 in silico tools predict pathogenic (SpliceAI/Pangolin>0.5, SPiP>0.9)
BP4	-1	>=3 in silico tools predict benign (SpliceAI/Pangolin<0.1, SPiP<0.3)
BP7	-2	No aberrant splicing observed AND wild-type transcript maintained

9. Reclassification Score Design (Ensemble 0-100)

All three models are loaded and run in parallel. The ensemble Reclassification Score (0-100) is a weighted average proportional to each model's mean CV AUC:

$$\text{Score} = 100 \times (\text{RF} \times 0.947 + \text{XGB} \times 0.940 + \text{LR} \times 0.935) / (0.947 + 0.940 + 0.935)$$

Score bands and clinical interpretation:

<30	Likely Benign (LB)
30-50	Uncertain -- lean benign (VUS-)
50-70	Uncertain -- lean pathogenic (VUS+)
>=70	Likely Pathogenic / Pathogenic

SHAP (TreeExplainer) values from RandomForest are computed per prediction, showing which features pushed the score up or down. The ACMG evidence summary (which rules fired) is displayed alongside, supporting clinical auditability.

10. Roadmap: Prototype to Clinical Tool

Phase	Action	Impact
Short	External cohort validation (LOVD / ClinVar)	Confirm generalisability beyond Erasmus MC
Short	Probability calibration (Platt scaling)	Calibrated confidence for clinical use
Short	Gene-level stratification analysis	Assess NF1/TSC-specific vs global model
Medium	Train neurodisorder-specific sub-model	NF1, TSC1/2, SHANK2, UBE3A domain adaptation
Medium	Local VEP v105 installation	178/178 VEP coverage (current 164/178)
Medium	SpliceAI auto-fetch via Illumina Basespace	Remove manual score entry burden
Long	Prospective validation (ACMG Level 5)	Clinical-grade certification evidence
Long	ISO 13485 / IVD compliance framework	Regulatory pathway for diagnostic use
Long	REDCap / LIMS API integration	Lab workflow embedding

10.1 On the Validation Set Question

With n=178, a fixed 80/20 holdout would yield only ~36 test variants, producing high-variance estimates (95% CI on AUC ~+/-0.06). Stratified 5-fold CV is the statistically appropriate choice at this sample size.

For the next phase, a minimum of 150 additional variants from an independent laboratory constitutes a proper external validation set. Sources: LOVD, ClinVar LP/P submissions with RNA evidence, and disease-specific registries for NF1 (NF1 MMDb) and tuberous sclerosis (TSC Alliance).

11. Limitations

- Sample size:

n=178 is small for clinical-grade ML. Results are a proof of concept for the BIRAC-BIOAI proposal, not a regulatory-grade validation.

- Gene-level bias:

NF1 comprises 25/178 (14%) of variants. If the model learns "NF1 = LP/P" rather than functional patterns, it will fail on other NF1 VUS. Gene-stratified CV is recommended for next-phase analysis.

- RNA assay context:

Training data use minigene assays, not patient-derived cells or patient RNA. Performance in clinical RNA diagnostic assays may differ.

- VEP coverage:

164/178 annotated via REST API. 14 variants use median imputation for VEP-derived features. Local VEP v105 installation will close this gap.

- gnomAD AF:

Variant-level AF was not fetched successfully for most variants. PM2 criterion defaults conservatively to "assume rare if no AF data".

- Internet dependency:

External annotation fetch (gnomAD, GTEx, VEP) requires internet. Offline mode uses stored training medians as substitutes.

- Temporal bias:

All variants from one 2026 publication; reclassification under updated criteria (ClinGen 2023, SVI 2022) has not been assessed.

12. References

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